never created an obvious monumental sculpture in relation to the Wall, his concerns and nuanced observations were deeply tied to his study of divided Berlin's physical contours. The survey allowed him to balance large-scale work at his foundry in Baarlo with a more mobile approach to contend with the massive border wall in Berlin. Further, though he began with this study a longer-term exploration of photographic techniques, he did not view himself as a fine art or documentary photographer. As Els Barents suggests, Tajiri was "not concerned with *pure photography*. … [He] only began to experiment with photography when he felt sure of his position as a sculptor."[11] Tajiri's other photographic undertakings regularly involved building physical devices for enhanced public viewing or adding layered inscriptions on his own prints.

As a whole, Tajiri's Berlin Wall project does powerfully share many aspects of his other artworks, including his reflections on technologies of war, his unpacking of a deep memory of internment, and his ongoing critical relationship to his status as an American. Tajiri never explicitly stated that he saw the Wall as related to his experiences in the internment camp or the segregated army. He did, however, continually insist that creating artwork was a mode of self-reflection and discovery and that he would spend the rest of his life processing the loss of his family's home and status as an American expatriate. Barents adds, "An immaterial quality of emulsion on a piece of paper was, for him, not a goal in of itself. … It was sooner an adventurous tour through the dark alleys and ghettos of the subconscious, which, as he now knows later in life, all end up in one point, that of the recollection."[12] Tajiri produced his photographs as a sculptural study of the Wall and, in turn, while moving through the geopolitical American borderlands of Berlin, mapped the meandering path of his own circuits of alternative cultural diplomacy.

A closer examination of Tajiri's process also sheds light on a significant, often understudied period of Berlin Wall history: the more than two decades during which both Germanys and their allies adjusted to the fact of its existence without knowledge that it would one day fall. For the Western powers, this meant not withdrawing the goal of free access to the entire city but, nonetheless, shifting away from the contest over the Wall as the focus of their Berlin policy. For the GDR's leadership, the fact of the Wall's endurance affirmed the goal of making the structure alternately more functional and estimable. The signing of the Four Powers Agreement in 1971, and its